important imperial buildings on top of Raisina Hill that 'exemplified the Raj ruling over the people of India' and created a 'big processional route [to them] that you have to go up as supplicants,' the Modi government's approach was the opposite. 'What we are doing here, and this present Prime Minister has sort of mandated, is that all the government facilities are going to come in the area on the plains, so to say, including the Prime Minister's office. And these magnificent buildings, which were the symbol of the government on top of the hill, are going to become museums … Now you're going to be able to walk up with your kids, go into these buildings, to the museums, where you will be able to enjoy our culture. Now, this is a complete reversal. You're putting the people on top, and you're putting the government below, in a sense.'[32]

The current governmental heart of Delhi, with its imposing central structures and colonial bungalows, was originally built by the British architects Sir Edward Lutyens and Sir Herbert Baker in the 1920s. Nehru's India added a new layer of ministerial offices—like Krishi Bhawan and Udyog Bhawan—to it after Independence. 'These buildings built in the 1960s are hideous,' Hardeep Singh Puri, Union minister for housing and urban affairs, has said. 'You have to build to new, higher environmental standards.'[33] Durga Shanker Mishra, secretary for housing and urban affairs, wrote that the 'roots of the country's democracy date back to ancient times. However, the six centuries of the Sultanate and Mughal era were a period of regression.' The new Parliament, designed to be a 'People's Parliament' was being built, he said, 'for the first time in the history of the country' as an 'intrinsic part of the vision for New India@75'.[34] In their view, then, central Delhi was built by colonial overlords, with Nehruvian India appropriating it. Shahjahanabad, the Delhi that preceded it, was built by the Mughals in the seventeenth century, following a long pedigree of rulers who built similar citadels. The Central Vista project would be very much a part of this history of a permanent architectural legacy.

Modi's 'New India' was essentially recasting the nation's capital for itself—a monument to the electoral triumphs that endorsed its thinking. 'Our vision is of a new India that will be in tune with its glorious past,' the prime minister announced in an election rally in